



SHIV KUMAR PUSHPAKAR

Olympics, and we received much help. We were a team worthy of winning the gold.

We had some tough matches in the competition. There was this classic match against Kenya that stayed in the minds of our fans. They had many who had migrated from India. Kenya took the lead twice before Mukhbain Singh equalised, and Harmik Singh hit the match-winner. It was one of the most exacting matches that I have played. We won the bronze medal with a hard-earned 2-1 win over the Netherlands. I can say today, the bronze medal had little value, considering our rich hockey legacy.

The final was a scrappy affair between Pakistan and West Germany.

The Pakistanis kept protesting every decision and mocking the spirit of the game. Their fans came onto the field and forced a halt. Pakistan refused to accept the result, and 11 players from the team were banned for life when they showed their backs to the German flag at the medal ceremony. The punishment was later reduced to two years by the international hockey federation, but it was a blot on

Pakistan, which had won the 1968 Olympic gold in Mexico, the 1970 Asian Games and the 1971 World Cup. Pakistan showed an inferior spirit with their awful behaviour. There was history behind that bad blood between the teams from their 1968 encounter. The umpiring was very poor, and Pakistan felt cheated.

For us, what remained in memory was the attack by the Palestinian Black September group, who targeted members of the Israeli athletes at the Olympic Village. Eleven Israelis and five Palestinian attackers died after a gunfight. The competitions resumed after a day's mourning. We woke up to armymen taking over the Village and helicopters hovering in the sky. The terrorists, somebody told us, worked at the Village and knew the place inside out.

It took me back to the 1964 final match between India and Pakistan. It was contested bitterly with a lot of rough play. The first five minutes saw the players going for each other. The umpires stopped the play, called both teams and told us, "From now on, only the red card will be in use. Any

minor foul will fetch a red card." The teams played some outstanding hockey after that warning. Looking at the performances in Munich, Mark Spitz of America won seven gold medals in swimming and won the hearts of all of us. What an amazing athlete he was! Watching Lasse Viren of Finland was a privilege, as he won the 5000 and 10000 gold medals.

Looking back I also have some pleasant memories of Munich. Sports help you understand each other. The Games Village was like a festival. We would exchange gifts, lapel pins, and pocket flags. It was my final Olympics. I was happy to make it three-in-a-row.

I am excited that the team is preparing well for the Paris Olympics. My only issue is the need for more consistency. We have to give our best. Losing 5-0 to Australia can be worrisome, but we have time to recover. We have to be ready for Ireland and New Zealand. They play fearless hockey. We have to ensure that we don't slacken. Each match has to be treated as a final. My best wishes to the team to improve the third-place finish in Tokyo.

As told to Vijay Lokapally